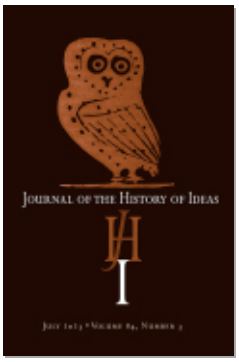
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Samuel Moyn

Of the innumerable interpretations of Hannah Arendt's political thought, not one has placed her alongside the founding Cold War liberals—her contemporaries and, in later life, her companions—though doing so is indispensable and overdue.[1] Such a comparison reveals that, like Isaiah Berlin, Karl Popper, Judith Shklar, Jacob Talmon, or Lionel Trilling, Arendt is best understood as displacing the intellectual premises of earlier liberalism, while foreclosing a global approach to the universalization of freedom and equality in an era of decolonization and deracialization. Generations of instrumentalizing, opportunistic, or promotional readings have obscured the relationship that Arendt sustained with the Cold War liberals. Restoring it to view helps reassess the contributions and limits of her project in political theory.

This article shows how Hannah Arendt is usefully reinterpreted in view of Cold War liberalism, the obverse goal from a lecture on her from a forthcoming book, which reinterprets Cold War liberals in light of her example. See Samuel Moyn, *Liberalism against Itself: Cold War Intellectuals and the Making of Our Times* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2023). Thanks to the editors of and referees for the *Journal of the History of Ideas* for help shifting agendas.

[1] For a rare and technical exception that proves the rule, see Danielle Judith Zola Carr, "'Ghastly Marionettes' and the Political Metaphysics of Cognitive Liberalism: Anti-Behaviourism, Language, and the Origins of Totalitarianism," *History of the Human Sciences* 33 (2020): 147–74.

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Arendt wasn't a liberal, she repeatedly declared—and she was therefore not a Cold War liberal.[2] If anything, she initiated more direct conversations with conservative traditions: her esteem for Edmund Burke ran high, and for Friedrich von Gentz even higher.[3] But even as she crafted her own idiosyncratic canon in the history of political thought, her very attempt to strike out on her own in developing a new account of freedom proved hostage to many of the intellectual and political premises of Cold War liberalism. A sketch of her biography resembles that of other Cold War liberals. Arendt was raised in Königsberg (where her family moved in 1909, three years after her birth), only 250 miles from Berlin's and Shklar's Riga. And Arendt was famously a Jewish exile, as most Cold War liberals were. But such biographical commonalities were never determinative, certainly not compared to the controversial intellectual choices she and the Cold War liberals made.[4]

It is critical to my account of Arendt and Cold War liberalism alike that both departed from earlier liberalism. Nowadays there is far more agreement than ever before that nineteenth-century Continental Europe birthed liberalism, in a radically different guise from the twentieth-century Anglophone constructions that center on early modernity, personal liberty, and religious toleration.[5] According to the recent literature, the founders of liberalism in the nineteenth century went on a rescue mission to integrate the emancipatory freedom and equality of the French Revolution with institutional stability and orderly progress.[6] They were, in this regard, fellow travelers of G. W. F. Hegel, who in turn anticipated the spirit of and profoundly influenced much later liberal theory. The practice of nineteenth-century liberalism gravitated to free markets and parliamentary institutions.[7] But the influence of the Romantic movement and certain forms of post-revolutionary

[2] See, e.g., Hannah Arendt, "A Reply," *Review of Politics* 15 (1953): 80.
[3] Margaret Canovan, "Hannah Arendt as a Conservative Thinker," in Larry May and Jerome Kohn, eds., *Hannah Arendt: After Twenty Years* (Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, 1996); Anna Jurkevics, "Hannah Arendt Encounters Friedrich von Gentz: On Revolution, Preservation, and European Unity," *Modern Intellectual History* 19, no. 4 (2022): 1134–56.
[4] Compare the biographically essentialist accounts in Seyla Benhabib, *Exile, Statelessness, and Migration: Playing Chess with History from Hannah Arendt to Isaiah Berlin* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2018) or Pierre Birnbaum, *The Geography of Hope: Exile, Enlightenment, Disassimilation* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2008).
[5] Duncan Bell, "What Is Liberalism?," *Political Theory* 42 (2014): 682–717.
[6] Helena Rosenblatt, *The Lost History of Liberalism: From Ancient Rome to the Twentieth Century* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2018).
[7] See, e.g., Gregory Conti and William Selinger, "The Lost History of *Political* Liberalism," *History of European Ideas* 46 (2020): 341–54.

Christianity on founders like Benjamin Constant and Alexis de Tocqueville placed a perfectionist account of the creative highest life at the core of its theorization, in the tracks of Hegel's attempt to institutionalize Romanticism in a collectively durable fashion.[8]

Of course, one impulse in this liberalism was calling for limits to the state to prevent excessive interference with individual and group self-creation, as demonstrated by Englishman John Stuart Mill—a clear follower of perfectionist authors prizing creativity as the highest life. But liberalism was not a libertarian project; as Edmund Fawcett remarks, in understanding its origins and trajectory, "liberty is the wrong place to begin."[9] Indeed, liberalism's commitment to collective and not just individual forms of perfectibility made group emancipation and national "genius" developing in historical time essential. Though notoriously imperial in its relation to non-Christian and non-white peoples, liberalism was anything but nonviolent in its attitude to imperial oppression in Europe itself, and it worked in and through nationalist emancipation—at least for Christians and whites—and not merely through individual freedom from the state.[10]

Both Arendt and the Cold War liberals broke almost entirely with this past, and that rupture is at the heart of their initiatives. The self-consciously new kind of disabused liberalism forged amid the desolation and disaster of the twentieth-century departed from earlier liberalism in several pivotal respects. Cold War liberals repudiated earlier trends—as well as the emerging attempt by late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century liberals to save the moral ideals of liberalism from the politics of free markets and trade—out of concern that totalitarians had arrogated the future, claimed the mantle of humanity, and converted individual and collective perfection into an alibi for terror. In response, Cold War liberals created a libertarian version of liberalism focused on keeping governmental tyranny at bay and state power within strict limits.

Named by their New Left critics—with a label that was subsequently reclaimed to praise them—Cold War liberals forged their views in the heat of World War II or even before. They offered, as their generally laudatory

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[8] Alexandre Lefebvre, "Liberalism and the Good Life," *Journal of Social and Political Philosophy* 1 (2022): 152–68.

[9] Edmund Fawcett, *Liberalism: The Life of an Idea* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2014), 15.

[10] See, e.g., Jennifer Pitts, "Political Theory of Empire and Imperialism," in *Empire and Modern Political Thought*, ed. Sankar Muthu (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012).

recent interpreters have insisted, a "politics of knowledge" that sought political moderation in an age of extremes.[11] They reclaimed liberty and responsibility in the face of the contingencies of history—disavowing trust in a historical process that so frequently went grotesquely wrong. And they reconceived liberalism in light of the allegedly enduring realities of human aggression or sin, which placed strict limits on the prospects of emancipation. Democracy itself was an ever-present threat to liberal freedom, and old and once-liberal notions of emancipation and perfectibility—not to mention once-liberal hopes for their availability in an unfolding secular history—were now targeted as lures that tempted the credulous into the arms of tyrants. And though there was one great exception, the Cold War liberals entirely dropped collective emancipation as an aspect of the liberal project. Not coincidentally or insignificantly, neoliberalism has defined the time ever since the years during which Arendt and Cold War liberals—in spite of their differences—liquidated prior liberalism from their positions beyond and within the liberal tradition respectively.

Placing Arendt in relation to Cold War liberals exemplifies some of the most arresting and important features of her thought. The comparison shows that she made far more room than they did for creative perfection, even as she followed later Romantics—Friedrich Nietzsche, above all—in surmising that it was fated to be evanescent and rare in an age of suffocating conformism. And she did not so much sternly reject modern democracy as idealize a vision of political action and associate it exclusively with so exceptional and even melodramatic a set of examples that she ended up rendering action incompatible with institutional life. Arendt's theory of freedom was thus irreducible to a political ethics of noninterference, including along the lines that Berlin (who despised her personally) made famous.[12] Yet even between Arendt and Berlin, there was as much commonality as difference. Both broke with earlier liberalism, in a rupture that Arendt assisted the Cold War liberals in introducing.

That rupture went far beyond Arendt's obvious and prime contribution to the development of the concept of totalitarianism that the Cold War

[11] See esp. Jan-Werner Müller, "Fear and Freedom: On 'Cold War Liberalism,'" *European Journal of Political Theory* 7 (2008): 45–64. See also Joshua L. Cherniss, *Liberalism in Dark Times: The Liberal Ethos in the Twentieth Century* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2021).

[12] See esp. Isaiah Berlin, *Two Concepts of Liberty: An Inaugural Lecture Delivered Before the University of Oxford on 31 October 1958* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1961). See Kei Hiruta, *Hannah Arendt and Isaiah Berlin: Freedom, Politics, and Humanity* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2021), chap. 2 on his disdain.

liberals likewise made central to their analysis of the twentieth century. Arendt overlapped with her generational companions, in particular, in abandoning the emergent prior liberal project associated with securing the institutional conditions—including the economic conditions—for the emancipation of creative agency or collective enjoyment of freedom. Arendt sometimes channeled an early nineteenth-century commitment to creative perfectionism in a modernist key but did not believe in the need, or even the possibility, of elaborating any institutional basis for realizing creative perfectionism on a mass scale. If it is correct to say that Arendt was a reluctant modernist, in spite of her own self-presentation as a retriever of ancient wisdom, it is also essential to note that she verged on a "strange" kind of Cold War liberalism in that very stance.[13]

Even more significantly, a comparison between Arendt and the Cold War liberals reveals a common relation to the most extraordinary development of their time: global decolonization. This was no accident; their common reaction to decolonization mirrored their relationship to the prior liberalism they both abandoned. Put another way, the intellectual premises of a good part of decolonization after 1945 were in the earlier liberalism that both Arendt and the Cold War liberals rejected. Recent literature stresses alternatives to nationalism or preemptively defines nationalism as illiberal, obscuring the profound impact of liberal nationalism in modern global history.[14] And the perfectionist and progressivist framing of liberalism that had prevailed before the Cold War redefined liberalism across the Atlantic remained a prominent feature of liberalism as it went global in the great springtime of nations after 1945. This was precisely the time when Arendt dismissed non-white bids for freedom and when metropolitan Cold War intellectuals altered the liberal creed they inherited so tremendously.

The most pressing but undiscussed rationale for reassessing the Cold War liberals is owing to their relationship to the unprecedented globalization of freedom that resulted from decolonization. And for this purpose, Arendt's far more open skepticism (indeed, racialized skepticism) helps dramatize why both her thought and theirs ought to be treated as irretrievable in our time. For all the ancient and Continental appurtenances of her philosophy, Arendt joined Cold War liberal Atlanticism—but sought to defend

[13] Seyla Benhabib, *The Reluctant Modernism of Hannah Arendt* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 2000); Roger C. Boesche, "The Strange Liberalism of Alexis de Tocqueville," *History of Political Thought* 2 (1981): 495–524.

[14] But see C. A. Bayly and Eugenio Biagini, eds., *Giuseppe Mazzini and the Globalisation of Democratic Nationalism, 1830–1920* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008).

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and rehabilitate the Atlantic republican tradition within a more openly global perspective in the era when formal empire came to an end. Alas, she adopted and adapted the Cold War contrast of Western civilization against French revolutionary manias for the sake of a cynical rejection of the very idea of deracialized global freedom.

To a striking extent, indeed, Arendt and Cold War liberals alike assumed freedom was what the late Tyler Stovall has called "white freedom," beleaguered almost hopelessly in a world of non-white despotism.[15] Stovall argues persuasively that 1945 and Adolf Hitler's defeat came to imply the eventual if still incomplete deracialization of world order and an end to hierarchical visions of humanity. But neither Arendt nor early Cold War liberal theorists got the memorandum. Arendt especially epitomized this general fact about Cold War liberalism, caught up as she was in neo-imperial and racist entanglements that go entirely unmentioned in promotional accounts of Cold War liberalism and remain, even today, barely challenged.

Yet there is a proviso. From another, exceptional, and unique perspective—that of their Middle Eastern politics—Arendt allowed a profound challenge to prior liberal Eurocentrism, albeit briefly. Cold War liberals also indulged a Zionist exception to their Eurocentric geography, but did so more permanently than Arendt did. For a short time, Arendt idealized Palestine as a space of the very collective freedom and self-assertion (with violent means if necessary) idealized within earlier liberal traditions and which Cold War liberals forbade as perilous. Before transferring her loyalties to her adoptive country of the United States defending liberty against threat—and before longing in her theoretical writings for the politics of ancient Rome, revived only ephemerally in modern times—Arendt saw beyond the libertarian constraints of Cold War liberalism in her Zionism. The Cold War liberals did so themselves, and enduringly, despite the stark contradiction with their doctrines it involved.

THE FATE OF LIBERTY IN A TOTALITARIAN AGE

Visitors to Arendt's gallery of the annals of "Western civilization" will find her walls similar to the ones the Cold War liberals curated. They were almost completely barren when it comes to the Enlightenment and nineteenth-century liberalism. Yet she was as concerned as they were that the modern

[15] Tyler Stovall, *White Freedom: The Racial History of an Idea* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2021).

age had eventuated in an abasing new form of rule called "totalitarianism." Arendt's *The Origins of Totalitarianism* expounded her version of that Cold War truism.

It was in finalizing what had begun as a very different kind of book that Arendt vaulted herself from obscure journalist and solitary loner into the pantheon of Cold War critics of "totalitarianism." In the fires of World War II, anti-totalitarianism had become central to liberal thinking.[16] The pact between Adolf Hitler and Josef Stalin in in 1939, so disconcerting to antifascism, vindicated the originally center-right concept of "totalitarianism" that grouped illiberal regimes of left and right together—even though it would soon be undercut by a more left-leaning front against fascism. After 1945, the fragmentation of the alliance that had banded together to defeat the Axis revived anti-totalitarianism.

Indeed, had the original formulations of the nature of totalitarianism not been routinized in the invention of Cold War liberalism, it is doubtful that the notion would have survived. Cold War liberalism breathed new spirit into the concept of totalitarianism, which otherwise might not have endured after World War II when fascism disappeared as a living political endeavor, a few old and new redoubts in Iberia and the Global South aside. Arendt joined in theorizing it—towering above all others in the prominence of her rendition. For all her originality, in other words, Arendt's fame was parasitic on the crystallization of Cold War liberalism in the late 1940s.

Arendt's case raises the arresting irony that the thinker most enduringly associated with a concept engaged it accidentally and instrumentally. It is clear that when Arendt embarked in the United States on *The Origins of Totalitarianism* around 1946, with her background in existential philosophy and Jewish political journalism, it was solely intended as an autopsy of Nazi rule. "Although Arendt is known as one of the foremost proponents of the 'totalitarian' thesis," Margaret Canovan observes, "totalitarianism in [the] sense [of theorizing the two regimes together] was not in fact the original subject of her book, and [its] last and most influential section was largely an afterthought."[17] Arendt set out to plumb the sources of Nazism not solely in antisemitism but also in imperialism, which were the only two topics Arendt initially planned for the book.

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[16] For one survey, Samuel Moyn, "Critics of Totalitarianism," in *Cambridge History of Modern European Thought*, ed. Warren Breckman and Peter Gordon, 2 vols. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019). See also Anson Rabinbach, "Moments of Totalitarianism," *History & Theory* 45 (2006): 72–100.

[17] Margaret Canovan, *Hannah Arendt: A Reinterpretation of Her Political Thought* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 18.

Arendt's plans changed with the crystallization of the Cold War in 1947–48.[18] Shortly before the book's appearance in 1951, she wrote an additional, third part of the book on "totalitarianism," but its relation to the prior sections of her book as well as to earlier discourse on the subject remained unclear. She did not care to explain, and readers have long suspected that her rationale for adding the section on "totalitarianism" was largely opportunistic, an attempt to keep her original investigation of Nazism relevant in the guise of answering the concern about the Soviet Union that now prevailed. The British version of her book altered its famous American title to *The Burden of Our Time*, while the German version referred to "total domination" (*totale Herrschaft*) rather than "totalitarianism."[19] No matter: thanks to the smash hit she achieved with her topical book, Arendt was canonized as a pivotal thinker because she volunteered for the Cold War defense of freedom against the new form of rule that went beyond ancient typologies.

A DIFFERENT FREEDOM AND EQUALITY

Arendt's writing after *Origins of Totalitarianism* made clear that, while she popularized Cold War liberal concern with the extremist state of the twentieth century, she nonetheless also drew on Romanticism that Cold War liberals wished to expunge from their own tradition. The Cold War liberals repudiated Romanticism almost entirely—frequently blaming it for totalitarianism itself. They therefore cut the tether to earlier liberalism unceremoniously. Arendt's theory of political action, by contrast, was rooted in Romanticism even as she reconfigured it, making the sort of creative agency she idealized almost inaccessible in her very attempt to preserve it in an age of mass society.

The sources of Arendt's vision of political action as creative performance lay in late Romanticism, in Friedrich Nietzsche's aestheticism, as well as in Nietzsche's Weimar-era heirs.[20] But where Romantic liberals had contem-

[18] Roy Tsao, "The Three Phases of Arendt's Theory of Totalitarianism," *Social Research* 69 (2002): 580–619.

[19] Hannah Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1951); *The Burden of Our Time* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1951); *Elemente und Ursprünge totaler Herrschaft* (Frankfurt am Main: Europäische Verlagsanstalt, 1957). I cite the second enlarged American edition (1958) below.

[20] For the once common view of Nietzsche as a late Romantic, see, e.g., Karl Joël, *Nietzsche und die Romantik* (Jena: Eugen Diederichs, 1905).

plated the emergence and fulfillment of perfectionist creativity and universal emancipation in history, as well as in the political institutions of the modern state, Arendt centered her account on evanescent practices of banding together to shine forth in the face of oblivion and transience.[21] She had experienced some anticipation of the practices she had in mind before World War II in the French Resistance and Zionist politics, and she later prized them in the Hungarian experiment with council government in 1956 (before the Soviets crushed it). She even showed a soft spot for the early twentieth-century revolutionary Rosa Luxemburg, anathema to Cold War liberals.[22] But far from sympathizing with most new revolutions after 1945, which were located in the Global South, Arendt spent the Cold War projecting the politics she prized backward, associating agency with Rome and neo-Roman American origins.

It was in this vein that Arendt produced her fanciful interpretation of American colonists and revolutionaries as exemplars of the post-metaphysical politics she prized. Her narrative of American history before and during independence involved collective action, but neither emancipatory institutions nor ethical ends. Founding the United States did, however, provide the authoritative basis for social cohesion that Arendt believed moderns require because of their debts to the Christian past. Following the colonial practice of "covenants," American revolutionaries—unlike their French successors who paved the way to horror both immediately in 1789 and climactically in 1917—exemplified a promissory equality that allowed the revival of ancient "reconstitution" in modern post-Christian form. Unlike for some other Cold War liberals—such as the early Gertrude Himmelfarb, for whom 1776 marked the birth of liberalism in an appeal to eternal liberal norms—Arendt denied the relevance of natural law and rights in the revolutionary foundation of a "new order of the ages" (*novus ordo seclorum*).[23] But for Arendt, as for the "consensus" Cold War school of American historiography she followed, the American Revolution was about political freedom without the interference of economic justice. Reclaiming its distinctive model of politics

[21] Dana Villa, *Arendt and Heidegger: The Fate of the Political* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1996).
[22] Hannah Arendt, "A Heroine of Revolution," *New York Review of Books*, October 6, 1966; Sidonia Blättler and Irene M. Marti, "Rosa Luxemburg and Hannah Arendt: Against the Destruction of Political Spheres of Freedom," *Hypatia* 20 (2005): 88–101.
[23] Arendt, *On Revolution*, chap. 5. Compare Gertrude Himmelfarb, "The American Revolution in the Political Theory of Lord Acton," *Journal of Modern History* 21 (1949): 293–312.

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was critical for avoiding the totalitarian modernity that the French Revolution anticipated.

Arendt's interpretation of the American colonists was neo-Roman—though in a far more bizarre sense than the interpretation of those she influenced to celebrate the "Atlantic republican tradition."[24] She clearly owed her concept of political natality, as *On Revolution* shows, to the Weimar classicist Eduard Norden. Norden's once famous interpretation of Virgil's Fourth Eclogue—the poem that recounts the birth of a prophesied savior—read it as nourished by the same "oriental" messianic sentiment as had made Christianity imaginable.[25] The birth of the child in Virgil's poem announced an order of the ages (*ordo seclorum*) that American founders reclaimed as their own but retitled from being "great" (*magna*) to "new" (*novus*) to recognize the modern situation after Christianity that required authoritative grounding for politics. Though, unlike Norden, Arendt denied Virgil's poetry any religious content, she did see it as epitomizing the spiritual core of the neo-Roman political freedom she prized, a bid for "a sense of greatness and surpassing excellence" coupled with "the will to lend immortality to greatness by celebrating it."[26]

All this, clearly, was a world away from Cold War liberals whose response to totalitarianism was to reclaim freedom as "noninterference." Yet Arendt agreed with Cold War liberals about what threatened the precious legacy of freedom they theorized so differently. With her stance, Arendt clearly rejected Berlin's notion of negative liberty for a vision of nonsovereign freedom, as she called it. Comparably, though following them in prioritizing freedom over equality, she struggled to reclaim some form of the latter in her theory of political action (which banished distributional and other social forms of fairness). By contrast, some Cold War liberals dropped equality altogether and all of them emphasized that it functioned to extinguish freedom. Arendt thus went beyond Cold War liberalism in her vision

[24] For the best survey (which, however, omits Arendt's Virgiliana), see Dean Hammer, "Hannah Arendt and Roman Political Thought: The Practice of Theory," *Political Theory* 30 (2002): 124–49. On her legacy, Mira Siegelberg, "Things Fall Apart: J. G. A. Pocock, Hannah Arendt, and the Politics of Time," *Modern Intellectual History* 10 (2013): 109–34.

[25] Arendt, *On Revolution*, esp. 211–15, esp. 214 and 317n; Eduard Norden, *Die Geburt des Kindes: Geschichte einer religiösen Idee* (Leipzig: B. G. Teubner, 1924). On Hermann Broch's contribution, see, e.g., Austin Harrington, "1945: A New Order of the Ages," *Sociologisk Forskning* 45 (2008): 78–88.

[26] Hannah Arendt, "Introduction *into* Politics," in *The Promise of Politics*, ed. Jerome Kohn (New York: Schocken Books, 2005), 188.

of what was to be rescued from the Western tradition in a totalitarian and thoughtless age.[27]

It was not so much in Arendt's affections but in her hatreds that her ideas most clearly matched Atlanticist Cold War liberals: idealizing America (or sometimes England, as in Berlin's and Talmon's case) was a way to condemn modern thought and the politics of Continental Europe as fated for disaster. As a result, Arendt's otherwise promising attempt to rescue the kernel of earlier liberalism remained hostage to her decision to join the Cold War condemnation of its philosophical sources with such gusto.

FREEDOM AGAINST THE FRENCH REVOLUTION

Although she preserved creative action as an evanescent goal of politics, Arendt chimed with Cold War liberals in omitting any traces of nineteenth-century liberalism from their accounts of liberalism's historical emergence—Berlin's classic essay on Mill being the exception that proved the rule.[28] And she fully shared their obsession with the trajectory from Rousseau, through the French Revolution, culminating in twentieth-century horror.

Following her other constructive classic in political theory, *The Human Condition* (1958), Arendt's *On Revolution* (1963) famously drew on ancient inspiration—but for the sake of defending the American Revolution's Cold War freedom against the French Revolution's derangements.[29] In *On Revolution* Arendt covered Rousseau, the French Revolution, and Hegel by offering up what reads like a sophisticated rewrite of Talmon's Cold War liberal classic *Origins of Totalitarian Democracy* (which had appeared the year after her own book on totalitarianism, and which she owned). In her book and wider thought, Arendt's skepticism of Rousseau and Hegel, source and successor of the French Revolution, coincided with Cold War liberal scripts. One way of reading Arendt, in fact, is to observe her explicitly globalize her skepticism of the French Revolution's legacy in a decolonizing age where Cold War liberals more regularly presented a Soviet or domestic threat as the most terrifying one.

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[27] See Hiruta, *Hannah Arendt and Isaiah Berlin*, chap. 3.

[28] Isaiah Berlin, *John Stuart Mill and the Ends of Life* (London: Council of Christians and Jews, 1959).

[29] Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958); Hannah Arendt, *On Revolution* (New York: Viking, 1963). Compare Roy Tsao, "Arendt and the Modern State: On Hegel in *The Origins of Totalitarianism*," *Review of Politics* 66 (2004): 61–93.

It was in the course of her unforgiving treatment of the French scene in *On Revolution* that Arendt sided most clearly with Cold War liberals. "Every man must have an attitude to the French Revolution," English historian Herbert Butterfield remarked in 1949, "must make a decision about it somehow—as part of the stand that he generally takes in life."[30] Talmon was against it in part because he considered freedom from want as concession to a hedonism that led to totalitarianism. "Exasperated by famine and shortage," he had written, "the masses confusedly and passionately clamoured that the Revolution should carry out its promises, that is to say, should make them happy."[31] Arendt was against it too—and, like some other Cold War liberals, in favor of the American Revolution.

In her well-known critique of Arendt on the social question, political theorist Hanna Pitkin does not mention Talmon or explore the Cold War's relevance.[32] But it was absolutely essential to grasping how Arendt arrived at her notorious skepticism toward the social question. In some Canadian lectures, Butterfield—who was more conservative than Cold War liberals but also shared many of their assumptions—acknowledged that "fairer distribution of the world's goods" followed necessarily from the intuition that "without social justice many people can possess nothing more than the empty shell of a purely formal liberty." The trouble was the terrorism such a thought rationalized. "A whole civilization is being menaced if egalitarianism is turned into the absolute end."[33] Arendt, of course, agreed with such figures entirely.

Far from viewing the economic realm as the condition of the possibility of credible freedom of any kind, Arendt looked on the modern economy in terms of the necessity that ancients had associated with the ancient *oikos*. It followed that any project of public freedom had to be non-economic; suggesting otherwise risked missing the point of political action, or even misleading it by substituting the compulsive determinism of need for the public freedoms of politics. Indeed, Arendt condemned not just egalitarian reform but even more basic remedies for poverty as "foredoomed" to terror. Even

[30] Herbert Butterfield, *Christianity and History* (New York: Scribner, 1949), 11.
[31] Jacob L. Talmon, *The Origins of Totalitarian Democracy* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1952), 150.
[32] Hanna Fenichel Pitkin, *The Attack of the Blob: Hannah Arendt's Concept of the Social* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998).
[33] Herbert Butterfield, *Liberty in the Modern World* (Toronto: Ryerson Press, 1952), 56–57; but see the more conciliatory later passage in Herbert Butterfield, *Christianity, Diplomacy, and War* (New York: Macmillan, 1953), 118–21.

as liberals—including American ones—struggled to build welfare states after World War II, she followed her famous chapter in *On Revolution* warning against the enthronement of the social question with a chapter on the pursuit of happiness that purported to rescue American freedom from the terrible mistake of a politics of wants. "While it is true that freedom can come only to those whose needs are fulfilled," she conceded grudgingly, "it is equally true that it will escape those who are bent upon living for their desires."[34]

COLD WAR COUNTERHISTORICISM

Arendt also joined the repudiation of "reason in history" and the progressivism that liberals had accepted before the Cold War—perhaps the most fervently pursued renovation of their tradition attempted by Cold War liberals. Even as she engaged with Karl Marx as a theorist of work in *The Human Condition* and planned a major research project on his contributions to totalitarian ideology, Arendt assembled a familiar case against Hegelian historicism.[35]

In fact, Arendt's own Eurocentricity and even racialism—as we will see—placed her close to Hegel's assumptions about the eligible players in the world history of freedom. But in her own mind Arendt enthusiastically volunteered in the campaign against Hegelianism, elaborating a vision of our relation to the past that did not fall into the errors of secular historicism. Like Popper, she attributed it (and much modern thought) to a commitment to grim necessity that Berlin also denounced to great acclaim, though doing so required bowdlerizing Hegel's philosophy of history first.[36]

In an essay on Jewish history dated January 1946, Arendt had already expressed understandable skepticism of any notion that unreason and violence contributed to progress. The reversal of Jewish emancipation into genocide proved otherwise.[37] With recent manuscript publications, however, it is clearer that it was really in the critical decade of her evolution in

[34] Arendt, *On Revolution*, 136.
[35] On the Marx project and its significance in Arendt's evolution, see, e.g., Canovan, *Hannah Arendt*, chap. 8.
[36] Karl R. Popper, *The Open Society and Its Enemies*, 2 vols. (London: Routledge, 1945).
[37] Hannah Arendt, "Privileged Jews," *Jewish Social Studies* 8 (1946): 3–30, partially reprinted as "The Morals of History," in Hannah Arendt, *The Jew as Pariah: Jewish Identity and Politics in the Modern Age*, ed. Ron H. Feldman (New York: Schocken, 1978).

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between *Origins of Totalitarianism* and her more programmatic classics that she joined the Cold War liberal critique of claims on "history," if after her own fashion.[38] As her manuscripts show, Arendt's counter-historicism aspired to separate political action from the Hegelian frame that existentialists such as Maurice Merleau-Ponty were reconstructing. His approach, Arendt concluded after her Paris trips of 1951–52, fused a voluntarism at the opposite extreme from deterministic Marxism with an unearned trust that action would serve freedom.

In a crucial lecture at the American Political Science Association meeting in 1954, announcing the position of her coming programmatic works, Arendt praised Hegelianism, saying that "the modern concept of history . . . has given the realm of human affairs a dignity it never enjoyed in philosophy before." Even so, the search for freedom and intelligibility in history had now been bankrupted. "Today," she concluded derisively, "nothing appears more questionable than that the course of history in and by itself is directed toward the realization of more and more freedom. If we think in terms of recent trends and tendencies, the opposite seems more plausible."[39]

In response Arendt refused any notion of historical progress, striving for a philosophy of judgment and reconciliation that "generated a form of solidarity resting on an acceptance of wrongs as a feature of the world, without erasing their historical occurrence."[40] She had already been clear in the closing part of *Origins of Totalitarianism* about how "laws of history" no less than the "laws of nature" rationalized totalitarian wrongdoing.[41] Throughout the 1950s, she reinforced this conclusion. She did not take much interest in Berlin (though she never reached the contempt he had for her) and never read Popper. Unlike the debate between those Cold War liberals about whether to reconstruct historical inquiry according to a falsificationist philosophy of science or keep the study of history and nature separate, Arendt mainly worried that the modern age pitted the historical and the natural realms of determination against one another without finding room for freedom in either.[42] Nevertheless, her brief against Hegel's alleged ne-

[38] See Hannah Arendt, *The Modern Challenge to Tradition: Fragmente eines Buches*, ed. Barbara Hahn and James McFarland (Göttingen: Wallstein Verlag, 2018); Arendt, "From Hegel to Marx," in *The Promise of Politics*.

[39] Hannah Arendt, "Concern with Politics in Recent European Thought," in *Essays in Understanding, 1939–1954* (New York: Harcourt Brace, 1994), 444.

[40] Waseem Yaqoob, "Reconciliation and Violence: Hannah Arendt on Historical Understanding," *Modern Intellectual History* 11 (2014): 397.

[41] See, e.g., Arendt, *Origins*, 350.

[42] See Hannah Arendt, "The Concept of History: Ancient and Modern," in *Between Past and Future: Six Exercises in Political Thought* (New York: Viking, 1961).

cessitarianism, notably in a long passage of *On Revolution*, was roughly similar to theirs.[43]

This did not mean that Arendt relinquished the study of how the past produced the present. She thought she had provided an example in her totalitarianism study. It did not forbid, either, diving into history for the sake of a future discontinuous with the present, a practice Arendt associated with her German-Jewish friend Walter Benjamin and attempted to engage in herself, most clearly in *On Revolution*'s retrieval of the "lost treasure" of her idealized American colonists.[44] But from both perspectives, like Cold War liberals, Arendt dug the grave of reason in history; like them, she assigned blame to historicism for a twentieth-century violence that, far from serving as midwife of emancipation, birthed grotesque monsters instead.

Unlike the great many Cold War liberals who embraced religion's timeless values out of a critique of emancipation, Arendt was surely uncommitted to any such comfort. She nonetheless insisted that Christianity set nonnegotiable constraints on any retrieval of ancient traditions of political action.[45] She did not adopt any simpleminded version of the Cold War tropes that pitted Christendom against secularism. Unlike pivotal interlocutors such as Waldemar Gurian, Jules Monnerot, and Eric Voegelin, she did not develop a theory of communism as a "secular religion."[46] "In our struggle against Communism as a totalitarian system we are not defending specifically a 'religious system,' but a secular world in which free religion is possible like a great many other free human activities," she explained. "Communism, on the other hand, is not a religion."[47] But Arendt did argue very clearly that the intervention of Christianity in between the ancient and modern ages precipitated a need for the authority of a lawgiver and a fear of Hell that established limits, both of which proponents of modern secular freedom were required functionally to replace.[48]

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[43] Arendt, *On Revolution*, 45–49.

[44] Hannah Arendt, "Walter Benjamin, 1892–1940," in Walter Benjamin, *Illuminations*, ed. Arendt (New York: Schocken, 1968); Arendt, *On Revolution*, chap. 6.

[45] Samuel Moyn, "Hannah Arendt on the Secular," *New German Critique* 105 (2008): 71–96.

[46] Hannah Arendt, "Waldemar Gurian," in *Men in Dark Times* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1968).

[47] These lines come from a lecture version of "Religion and Politics" but did not make it into the printed essay. Compare Arendt, *The Modern Challenge to Tradition*, 221 with Arendt, "Religion and Politics," in *Essays in Understanding*. See also Peter Baehr, *Hannah Arendt, Totalitarianism, and the Social Sciences* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2010), chap. 3.

[48] Hannah Arendt, "What Is Authority?," in *Between Past and Future*.

Otherwise, Arendt thus shared the demonology of modern emancipation that the Cold War liberals pioneered, while retrojecting creative freedom into sources so distant that it was not obvious that her attempted preservation of what Berlin called "positive liberty" was more credible than the vituperation the Cold War liberals themselves visited upon it.

DECOLONIZATION AND DISASTER

Arendt's racialized skepticism of the prospects of global freedom in a decolonizing age was her tightest link with the Cold War liberals—and the fact that she was so much more forthcoming in this regard helps bring out this essential commonality. Berlin rarely commented publicly on political events of any kind, outside of Middle East politics—he made no public or private reference to Aden, India, Malaya, Kenya, or southern Africa, the most obvious sites of brutal decolonization in which his own country's empire was directly involved. The same was true of Popper and Talmon. (By the late 1960s these liberals, like Arendt, were eventually forced to meditate publicly on America's Indochinese fiasco.)[49]

By contrast, Arendt was open and unapologetic when it came to her imperialist and racist commitments. A generation of criticism has shown that her treatments of empire and race-thinking in *Origins of Totalitarianism* repeated prevalent assumptions about non-Europeans (and even about Jews). Nowhere did she anticipate the postcolonial charge that so-called totalitarianism was new only to those who disregarded and trivialized the sordid realities of centuries of colonial rule.[50] Arendt distinguished between ordinary and totalitarian racialism—between "race-thinking" and the "racism"

[49] Arendt and Berlin are both in Cecil Woolf and John Bagguley, eds., *Authors Take Sides on Vietnam* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1967). For Arendt's Vietnam-era engagements, see Hannah Arendt, *Crises of the Republic* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1972). See also Karl Popper, "How to Get Out of Vietnam," in *After the Open Society: Selected Social and Political Writings*, ed. Jeremy Shearmur and Piers Norris Turner (New York: Routledge, 2008).

[50] The pivotal collection is Richard H. King and Dan Stone, eds., *Hannah Arendt and the Uses of History: Imperialism, Nation, Race, and Genocide* (New York; Berghahn Books, 2007). Founded by Shiraz Dossa as far back as 1980, the literature continues in such works as Michael Rothberg, *Multidirectional Memory: Remembering the Holocaust in the Age of Decolonization* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2009), chap. 1, Karuna Mantena, "Genealogies of Catastrophe: Arendt on the Logic and Legacy of Imperialism," in *Politics in Dark Times: Encounters with Hannah Arendt*, ed. Seyla Benhabib et al. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012), and Vaughn Rasberry, *Race and the Totalitarian Century: Geopolitics in the Black Literary Imagination* (Cambridge,

that later nineteenth-century imperialism brought. Critics have dwelled with disappointment on Arendt's treatment of Africans. Identifying with Boer settlers, Arendt also reiterated the common perception of indigenous Africans as savages living in accordance with nature rather than creating "a human world, a human reality."[51]

With Arendt's neo-Roman politics, empire was one form of exemplary grandeur implicit in her call for collective action, even if she praised empires that followed Virgil's injunction to crown peace with justice, sparing the vanquished even while crushing the proud. What was at stake, Arendt thought, was not whether empire ascended in the first place, but whether it crossed irreversibly into decline, as she eventually ended up worrying America was doing in the era of its "crises of the republic" and the Vietnam War.[52] Arendt's racialism has drawn most attention among those who have engaged her notorious treatment of civil rights politics in her adopted country.[53] But it pervaded her work, openly or latently.

Concentrating on Arendt's comments on historic imperialism as decisive in the origins of totalitarianism or, later, on racial politics in her own country, however, scants the most obvious context for her mature thought: the beacon of American freedom shining forth amid global decolonization and deracialization. Restoring that context allows linking Arendt to Cold War thinkers—whose characteristic silences Arendt spoke through—in the most disturbing possible way. Early Cold War liberalism effectively restricted freedom to metropolitan centers, as the horrifying periphery threw in its lot with the nationalist and violent revolution of the French Revolution's aberrant tradition. In *On Revolution* and *On Violence* (1970), Arendt set out to defend this posture that the Cold War liberals were more coy in adopting. More clearly than any Cold War liberal classic, *On Revolution* encoded hierarchical assumptions in a deracializing age, before *On Violence* and Arendt's critique of armed struggle in the Global South (and thirdworldism in the north) made them entirely explicit.

MA: Harvard University Press, 2016). See also Jimmy Casas Klausen, "Hannah Arendt's Antiprimitivism," *Political Theory* 38 (2010): 394–423.

[51] Arendt, *Origins*, 192.

[52] The best source is Dirk Moses, "*Das römische Gespräch* in a New Key: Hannah Arendt, Genocide, and the Defense of Republican Civilization," *Journal of Modern History* 85 (2013): 867–913.

[53] Patricia Owens, "Racism in the Political Theory Canon: Hannah Arendt and 'the One Great Crime in Which America Was Never Involved,'" *Millennium* 45 (2017): 403–24. Compare Danielle Allen, *Talking to Strangers: Anxieties of Citizenship after Brown v. Board of Education* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2002).

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To begin with, Arendt's construal of Atlantic revolution in the late eighteenth century—American and French—perpetuated the discourse back to Gentz of comparing some revolutions while leaving others out. It has been charged, by Kathryn Gines among others, that Arendt juxtaposed the American and French while excluding the Haitian Revolution from her account of modern bids for freedom—though C. L. R. James had already written *Black Jacobins*, the text that has inspired contemporary scholars to rectify that error, and that James revised for republication in the same year as Arendt's *On Revolution*.[54] But the deeper anxiety is not exclusion and silencing—itself almost universal in the anatomy of revolution for centuries—so much as Arendt's clear assumption that non-white revolution would necessarily channel French manias. Had she included Haiti in *On Revolution*, Arendt would have found it pathological, merely worsening—if such were possible—the French syndrome, by welding political freedom not just to class but also to racial equality.

One doesn't need to read between the lines to understand *On Revolution* as fundamentally about postcolonial derangement. The setting of the book, Arendt states clearly, was a time when "revolution has become one of the most common occurrences in the political life of nearly all countries and continents."[55] No doubt the legacy of 1789 ran through 1917. But in her own time the revolutionary legacy had passed to the Global South. It was in the postcolony that the choice between the American and the French/Soviet models of revolution was live. Did Arendt even regard it as a choice? The French Revolution, establishing through Hegel the very notion of world politics, had already gone global. "The sad truth of the matter," she wrote, "is that the French Revolution, which ended in disaster, has made world history, while the American Revolution, so triumphantly successful, has remained an event of little more than local importance."[56] And wasn't it a foregone conclusion that, with their endemic poverty, the peripheral sites were already lost, making the adulation of American freedom more a matter of defending it amidst a global siege than hoping for its replication elsewhere? "Human life has been stricken with poverty since time immemorial," Arendt observed, "and mankind continues to labor under this curse

[54] Kathryn Gines, *Hannah Arendt and the Negro Question* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2014), 74; C. L. R. James, *Black Jacobins* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1938; New York: Viking, 1963).
[55] Arendt, *On Revolution*, 218.
[56] Arendt, *On Revolution*, 49.

in all countries outside the Western hemisphere."[57] The situation practically guaranteed pursuing blood-dimmed equality at the expense of class-free liberty. In fairness, nowhere in *On Revolution* does Arendt imply that there was a racial bar to achieving American freedom anywhere even as the French/Soviet model prevailed everywhere in the twentieth century—but her hopes for Global South emancipation as it was actually occurring were essentially nugatory all the same.

The terms of Arendt's critique in *On Violence* of the glorification of bloodshed in Frantz Fanon and, even more, Jean-Paul Sartre were thus already implicit in her earlier skepticism of global revolution.[58] *On Violence* merely provided her most direct comment on decolonization around the world, and unlike her bifurcated account of revolution, Arendt's repudiation of decolonization in her time was complete and unrelieved. She did not note that the American Revolution had itself been a kind of decolonization. Not that Arendt entirely ruled out the uses of violence across her career.[59] And while generally pathologizing non-white armed struggle abroad and at home in her time—downplaying that Americans themselves had founded their country through violent insurrection—Arendt indulgently noted that the willingness to kill for political ends was due "to the severe frustration of the faculty of action in the modern world."[60] Furthermore, having been tempted to read Hegel as an apologist for carnage earlier in her career, Arendt now exempted both Hegel and Marx from blame for postcolonial bloodthirstiness, as she saw it, that bore no relationship to the establishment of legitimate power for the sake of freedom. (Political trajectories after European empire were the fault of Georges Sorel, the proto-fascist French thinker from the turn of the twentieth century, she suggested.[61])

In spite of these details, Arendt's comments in her pamphlet on violence, alongside her contemptuous tone, intensified her position in *On Revolution* that globalizing postcolonial freedom was despotic in intent or effect. The difficulty of what the Americans achieved all those centuries ago probably meant their accomplishment was not available for others now, even for those who might keep in mind the risks of French debacles. Far from being long

[57] Arendt, *On Revolution*, 108.
[58] Hannah Arendt, *On Violence* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1970).
[59] Caroline Ashcroft, *Power and Violence in the Thought of Hannah Arendt* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2021).
[60] Arendt, *On Violence*, 83.
[61] Arendt, *On Violence*, 12, 20, 65, 69–72, 81.

overdue during the most liberatory era in world history, freedom was elusive to the point of foreclosure.

ZIONISM AS DECOLONIZATION

For Arendt as for the Cold War liberals, there was one main exception to the pessimism about or rejection of the prospects of global emancipation—Zionism.[62] Like the other Cold War liberals, Arendt understood racism as a racialized Jewish victim of antisemitism. But their response to that racism was a kind of Jewish concession. Jews could strive violently for political freedom when other global peoples were not entitled to do the same. Once again, Arendt's companionship with Cold War liberals forces a discomfiting perspective on her thought: like them, Arendt prized aspects of the collective and emancipatory legacy of prior liberalism for Jews but for no one else.

Arendt's embrace of popular and violent emancipation in her short-lived Zionism of the 1930s and early 1940s matched the comparable identifications of Cold War liberals, except that they did not follow her in abandoning Zionism in practice. Furthermore, lacking the desire Arendt preserved for emancipation in evanescent forms, the Cold War liberals tolerated a much more flagrant contradiction between their libertarian theories of freedom and their Zionist politics of collective emancipation. But like her, they allowed Jews in the Middle East a form of politics which was ruled out by the libertarian breviary developed for the West in the face of the Soviet enemy.

Arendt's political awakening had led her to embrace Zionism for a decade after 1933, prizing the activist (and even armed) political alternative it afforded Jews facing persecution. Then, with the Zionist choice in 1942–43 against the federalist Zionism she supported, Arendt dropped out of the movement. It has been noted how Arendt's onetime enthusiasm for

[62] Compare Arie Dubnov, "Can Parallels Meet?: Hannah Arendt and Isaiah Berlin on the Jewish Post-Emancipatory Quest for Political Freedom," *Leo Baeck Institute Year Book* 62 (2017): 27–51 and Arie Dubnov, *Isaiah Berlin: The Journey of a Jewish Liberal* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012). Hiruta, *Hannah Arendt and Isaiah Berlin*, chap. 2, traces the biographical divergence of the two to their Zionist disagreements, but does not systematically explore their relevance theoretically. More generally, see Richard J. Bernstein, *Hannah Arendt and the Jewish Question* (Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, 1996) and Martine Leibovici, *Hannah Arendt, une Juive: Expérience, politique et histoire* (Paris: Desclée de Brouwer, 1998).

Jewish self-emancipation was starkly in tension with her later writings. There may have been continuities between her Zionist past and her mature theory, too, if one supposes that in her high regard for Zionist self-assertion lay the seeds of a mode of political action she purified and projected backward after the Cold War dawned.[63] But the basic contradiction between her support for Jewish self-emancipation through Zionism—however abandoned—and her stringent attitude toward other forms of decolonization after World War II remains undeniable.

The political content of Arendt's Zionism was always vague. But she made a series of commitments in her Zionist phase that were not prominent in her later political thought and that she critiqued during the Cold War as others claimed postcolonial emancipation. The only response to centuries of racist subordination was, as she observed of Alfred Dreyfus's plight in 1942, "the stern Jacobin concept of the nation."[64] But no form of Jacobinism proved viable for other peoples. And she wrote favorably of armed Jewish self-defense, though it was associated with Vladimir Jabotinsky's Irgun paramilitaries (whom she denounced as fascists).[65] Arendt never hewed to the model of the nation-state—which in *Origins* she would insist was breaking down—and her model of Zionism combined localist and late imperial federalist elements. (Arendt eventually wrote favorably about the binationalism of the Brit Shalom intellectuals around first Hebrew University chancellor Judah Magnes, but Gil Rubin has shown that during wartime her politics consistently went in the direction of late imperial federalism.)[66]

Indeed, after the Biltmore Conference that she attended and especially during 1944, she came out against Zionism in the most explosive and provocative terms. In her essay "Zionism Reconsidered," published in 1945, Arendt alleged that the movement had effectively sided with Jabotinsky's Revisionism, embracing a Jewish version of German nationalism by aiming for a "Jewish state"—grievous not least for Arabs. It is a stance for which

[63] Caroline Ashcroft, "Jewishness and the Problem of Nationalism: A Genealogy of Arendt's Early Political Thought," *Modern Intellectual History* 14 (2017): 421–49.
[64] Hannah Arendt, "From the Dreyfus Affair to France Today," *Jewish Social Studies* 4 (1942): 217; Arendt, *Origins*, 106.
[65] Hannah Arendt, "Die jüdische Armee: Der Anfang einer jüdischen Politik?," *Aufbau*, November 14, 1941, and "Ceterum Censeo," *Aufbau*, December 26, 1941, translated in *The Jewish Writings*, ed. Jerome Kohn and Ron H. Feldman (New York: Schocken, 2007).
[66] Gil Rubin, "From Federalism to Binationalism: Hannah Arendt's Shifting Zionism," *Contemporary European History* 24 (2015): 393–414.

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Arendt has won admiration only belatedly.[67] And it is only fair to acknowledge that Arendt's ultimate rejection of Zionism targeted precisely the nation-state it enthroned: the political form that became globally prevalent in decolonization.

The correspondence between Arendt's Zionism and that of the Cold War liberals was nonetheless impressive. They more forthrightly and permanently hewed to Jewish nationalism and were more blatant in their contradictions since they did not theoretically preserve any legacy of a collective and emancipatory prior liberalism in doing so. It was as if there was a Jewish exception to their teachings, which makes their depression about postcolonial freedom more generally even more startling than Arendt's rejection of it.

Jacob Talmon is the clearest case. Understandably devoted to Zionism, which he once called "the most sublime of all national ideals in history," for a long time he simply compartmentalized it from his vilifications of messianism and voluntarism in European traditions. It was as if the Zionism Talmon supported did not owe many of its sources to the revolutionary nationalism he spent his career denouncing.[68] As one commentator rightly notes, he "lived in two worlds."[69] After 1967, the tension between Talmon's Zionism and the terms of his Cold War liberalism became extremely difficult to sustain.

Berlin is a more unusual specimen. Like Arendt, Berlin had no reason to affiliate with Jewish identity except to the extent his people were targeted for hatred. She had drunk deep at the well of the fin-de-siècle French-Jewish analyst of antisemitism, Bernard Lazare, who disparaged Jewish social climbing while counseling Jews to affiliate with their own rejection, in an anticipation of Jean-Paul Sartre's theory of the "authentic Jew" who owned the identity imposed on him, transmuting it from a source of abasement to one of pride.[70] Arendt might have been speaking not just of herself but of Berlin too when she remarked of Lazare and others that they "were turned into Jews by antisemitism."[71]

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[67] Hannah Arendt, "Zionism Reconsidered," *Menorah Journal* (1944), rpt. in Arendt, *The Jew as Pariah* and *The Jewish Writings*.
[68] Cited in Ezra Mendelsohn, "Jacob Talmon between 'Good' and 'Bad' Nationalism," *History of European Ideas* 34 (2008): 199.
[69] Malachi H. Hacohen, "Jacob Talmon between Zionism and Cold War Liberalism," *History of European Ideas* 34 (2008): 157.
[70] Hannah Arendt, "Introduction," in Bernard Lazare, *Job's Dungheap: Essays on Jewish Nationalism and Social Revolution* (New York: Schocken, 1948); Jean-Paul Sartre, *Anti-Semite and Jew*, trans. George J. Becker (New York: Schocken, 1948).
[71] Arendt, "From the Dreyfus Affair," 236.

In his most important essay of 1951 on these matters, Berlin developed an extended unfortunate analogy of a Jewish man with a hunchback who could respond to antisemitism by pretending he had no deformity, treating it as a privilege, or making it bad form for others to notice, even while "wear[ing] voluminous cloaks which concealed [its] precise contours."[72] Like so many political Zionists, Berlin's Zionism offered a normalization—the fourth alternative of a country in which deformity became the norm—that Jews could not have in the diaspora, at least no time soon. Berlin was challenged on this point by French Hegelian philosopher Alexandre Kojève, who remarked that Jews "have the most interesting history of any people," yet "now they want to be what? Albania?" In response, Berlin celebrated normality.[73]

Much less important to Berlin was what exact form of normalization the creation of the state of Israel supplied. Like Talmon, Berlin worshiped Chaim Weizmann for representing a kind of Anglophile Zionism, worrying about the Labor Zionists so influential in the founding and early years of Israel—to say nothing of the further left party, Mapam, which both Berlin and Talmon despised.[74] But, Berlin affirmed in 1973, "the degree to which [Israel] may have realised or disappointed the expectations of its various founders and supporters matters relatively little." It "achieved the essence" of its plan since Jews had the choice to stop wasting their time "wondering uneasily what they look like to 'the others.'"[75]

The French Cold War liberal Raymond Aron had provided the model for Sartre's theory of the "inauthentic Jew" created purely by the gaze of those who hate him. As with Arendt and Lazare, Berlin's affiliation with Sartre's theory—*les autres,* or the others, are those who bring Jews about—is very interesting. Unlike Aron, who became a Zionist only in response to the 1967 war, Berlin understood early on that the alternative to inauthenticity was not authenticity, as Sartre proposed, but instead

[72] Isaiah Berlin, "Jewish Slavery and Emancipation," originally published in the *Jewish Chronicle* across September and October 1951 and rpt. in *The Power of Ideas*, ed. Henry Hardy (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2000), here 175–76.

[73] The original source of the anecdote is Berlin, "A Nation among Nations," *Jewish Chronicle*, May 4, 1973, and it is repeated in Ramin Jahanbegloo, *Conversations with Isaiah Berlin* (New York: Scribner, 1992), 86.

[74] Isaiah Berlin, "Chaim Weizmann," in *Personal Impressions*, ed. Henry Hardy (New York: Penguin, 1980). On Mapam, see Arie Dubnov, "A Tale of Trees and Crooked Timbers: Jacob Talmon and Isaiah Berlin on the Question of Jewish Nationalism," *History of European Ideas* 34 (2008): 225.

[75] Berlin, "A Nation among Nations."

escape—fleeing antisemitism to a place Jews could evade stigma.[76] Zionism allowed, Berlin wrote, a "restoration of health to a social organism that, for notorious historical reasons, had had an abnormal development, and became maimed."[77]

But even Zionism as normalization through a nation-state of one's own required a collectivist and nationalist project of self-assertion. In relation to other self-determination movements, Berlin defined Zionism as "that last child of the European Risorgimento."[78] In an edgy moment, he affirmed that calling Zionism "the decolonisation of the Jews everywhere" was "a brilliant simile."[79] Yet Berlin did not defend or extenuate decolonization elsewhere.

It was in part because Berlin understood Zionism's roots in nineteenth-century thought—crossing into its Romanticism, Hegelianism, and historicism—that sometimes he could be half-sympathetic to "the nations," as he once put it, "which feel that they have not yet played their part (but will) in the great drama of history."[80] As with the contrast between Arendt's more short-lived Zionism and her later political thought, however, the disparity between Berlin's more long-lived Zionism and his far less indulgent attitude toward other new states after World War II was undeniable. He felt free to criticize "the resentful attitude of those new nations which have exchanged the yoke of foreign rule for the despotism of an individual or class or group in their own society, and admire the triumphant display of naked power, at its most arbitrary and oppressive, even where social and economic needs do just call for authoritarian control."[81] The tension with Berlin's attitude toward that other new state of Israel—which didn't invite the criticism targeting postcolonial states—was glaring. Postcolonial emancipation was not just necessary but moving—for one people.

The collectivist and historicist liberalism, and even liberal socialism, to which the tradition sometimes seemed to be leading, was rejected emphatically by the Cold War liberals in the theoretical recasting of their tradition

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[76] Raymond Aron, *De Gaulle, Israël, et les juifs* (Paris: Plon, 1968).
[77] Berlin, "A Nation among Nations."
[78] Berlin "Jewish Slavery," 183.
[79] Berlin, "A Nation among Nations."
[80] Isaiah Berlin, "The Bent Twig: On the Rise of Nationalism," *Foreign Affairs* 51 (1972), rpt. In *The Crooked Timber of Humanity*, 2nd ed., ed. Henry Hardy (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2013), 263.
[81] Isaiah Berlin, "Rabindranath Tagore and the Consciousness of Nationality," in *The Sense of Reality: Studies in Ideas and Their History* (New York: Farrar, Straus, and Giroux, 1997), 258.

in the 1940s and migrated to the postcolonial world precisely then, and not just through Israel's founding. It was in part for this reason, we now know, that neoliberal "globalists" extended their own censorious attitude toward nationalism to the world stage.[82] Arendt more briefly, and the Cold War liberals permanently, supported nationalism only in one specific locale, even while turning against it globally—if for very different reasons than neoliberals had to do so.

For this reason, the great use of reading Arendt alongside Cold War liberals in the age of decolonization is to consider the geographical morality they shared.[83] They offered Cold War libertarianism for the transatlantic "West," an emancipatory statism (with violence if necessary) in their Zionist politics, and a caustic skepticism about the fate of freedom in either form elsewhere, based on an implicitly hierarchical set of assumptions about the world's peoples. If this is right, their establishment of that special category for Jews in the Middle East is compelling and remarkable, for its very existence—as the sole place in their thought where earlier forms of liberalism with their activism and statism were allowed to survive—represents a fundamental challenge to their call for limits in developed countries and anxieties about meaningless violence in developing ones. To the extent that Zionism allowed a last remnant of the earlier philosophy of liberal emancipation they all liquidated, perhaps Arendt, like the Cold War liberals, wasn't Zionist enough.

CONCLUSION

It was in part because Arendt did things other than encode Cold War liberalism that she has inspired a riot of successor projects, from accounts of participatory democracy to theories of republican freedom. C. L. R. James's brilliant reinterpreter David Scott—while indicting Arendt's erasure of Haiti—remarks, and rightly so, that "if in all the conventionally recognizable ways Arendt was a Eurocentric, this is not all that she was."[84]

Arendt may have betrayed the aspiration to creative agency for individuals and groups of earlier liberalism grievously, but less grievously than

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[82] Quinn Slobodian, *Globalists: The End of Empire and the Birth of Neoliberalism* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2018).

[83] Compare Dubnov, *Isaiah Berlin*, 197: "There was no contradiction between Berlin's diaspora Zionism and his antitotalitarian liberalism."

[84] David Scott, *Conscripts of Modernity: The Tragedy of Colonial Enlightenment* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004), 219.

Cold War liberals. And she paradoxically did so in the name of preserving it, even as she condemned it to practical unavailability. It is possible that even Arendt's Eurocentricity and racism are of value in casting the more extraordinary contradiction of Cold War liberals into relief. One of Arendt's great legacies, therefore, is the question of how to resolve that contradiction for thinking about collective political freedom in the future, beyond the legacy of local and global color lines.

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